

PROMPT: twenty stingers, round two

Supersedes `prompt-stinger-round-1.md`. Same three models, run independently, collated blind.

Round one produced roughly 120 lines across three models and one reader scored 67 of them. Every model landed on the same mean, about 3 out of 10, which means the failure was in the brief and not in who wrote it. **This version is rebuilt from that scoring rather than from more research.**

Still attach `SAS/true-crime-genre-deep-research-report.pdf`. The five aims below still come from it. What has changed is that we now have sixty-seven scored items from the actual decision-maker, which is better evidence for this particular decision than any study.

PASTE FROM HERE

Write **twenty** episode ideas for a true-crime podcast set in a contemporary mid-size coastal city. **A title and one sentence each. Nothing else.**

This is round two. Round one produced about a hundred and twenty of these and one reader scored sixty-seven. **The average was three out of ten and about half of everything he read got the same verdict: "maybe a seed here for a later episode."** That verdict is the target of this brief.

★ THE ONE THING THAT WENT WRONG

We generated good episodes and no episode ones.

Half the field was not rejected. It was deferred. A story can be interesting, well made and worth telling and still be wrong for a pilot, and round one never said what the difference was. **Here it is.**

A later episode has to be interesting to somebody who already likes the show. A pilot has to stop a stranger who has never heard of it.

That is a much higher bar and it is the only bar that matters here. **Before you write each line, ask: would somebody who has never heard of this show, reading at speed, with no reason to care, stop?** If the honest answer is *they would if it were explained to them*, you have written a later episode. **Write a different one.**

★ THE SECOND THING THAT WENT WRONG, AND IT KILLED A THIRD OF THE FIELD

The single most common reason a line scored zero was that the reader did not understand it. Thirteen separate kills, comments reading only "*Confusing*", and twice a direct question back: "*what does the*

dress on the church steps mean??" and *"protecting from what?"*

This was not a failure of ideas. It was a failure of sentence construction, and one model in particular bought space by withholding and inverting: *"and the person who noticed was not the police"*, *"which of them she was protecting"*. **Compression is not intrigue.**

So:

- **One read, at speed, no going back.** The reader is scanning a list of sixty. He will not re-read a line to be fair to it.
- **Say the thing, then turn it.** Subject, verb, object, then the fact that changes it. **No inversions. No withholding. No riddles.**
- **A reader must be able to say what the puzzle is, in his own words, the moment he finishes the sentence.** If he has to hold two half-facts in tension to work out what you mean, it is too clever and it will score zero.
- **Spend your words on being understood, not on being economical.** Thirty-five words is a limit, not a target.

★ WHAT ACTUALLY SCORED, WITH THE SCORES

Every high scorer has the same two things: a relationship you can name in two words, and one clean impossible fact stated straight.

8.5 — *Five Keys After Midnight.* Five friends receive keys after a woman's murder, each opening the cupboard where she hid proof that one of them planned her death. **Reader: "definitely intriguing."**

8 — *In Her Handwriting.* Her brother had begged her for months to help him die, and when he finally fell from the lighthouse, the note in his pocket was in her handwriting, but not her words.

7.5 — *The Woman in the Photograph.* Her husband reported her missing on a Tuesday and by Friday he had chosen the photograph the papers would use, and it is not one she would ever have picked.

7 — *The Man Who Waited.* He sat with her family every day of the trial, brought them food, and cried when the verdict came in; he had killed her in March.

7 — *The Intruder Had a Key.* A husband kills an intruder and is praised for saving his family, but the dead man carried a house key and had been sending money to the wife.

7 — *The Man Who Confessed Twice.* A dockworker confessed to a murder he could not describe, then died in custody, while the victim's brother quietly took over his home and family.

★ Notice what none of them do. Not one holds anything back. Not one requires a second read. **The interest is in the situation, not in the telling.**

Nothing has yet scored above 8.5. That is the number to beat.

★ WHAT DIED, AND THE READER'S OWN WORDS

Verdict	What it killed
"Confusing"	Thirteen lines. The largest single cause of death
"Unbelievable incompetence" · "Unbelievable"	Any line where the reason nobody looked is that everyone was stupid. Professionals in these stories are competent. Name a reason the thing was missed that is not somebody being an idiot
"Mechanics signing paperwork is boring"	Anything turning on a form, a ledger, a notebook of debts, an inspection, a signature or a record
"No kids" · "No old or young victim in ep1"	★ See the prohibitions
"No grab"	A line whose <i>title</i> smelled of admin, even though the sentence did not. The title is read first and it can kill a good sentence on its own
"Weak sauce"	A turn that rests on a technicality rather than on a person

WHAT EVERY ONE MUST CONTAIN

A death, and for this batch a murder in nearly all of them. Twelve testers rejected the last pilot with the words *"no jeopardy, too safe, not real true crime."*

FIVE THINGS TO AIM AT

From an independent evidence-led study of why true crime holds an audience. **Aims, not gates.**

- 1. A consequential question, not a crime category.** *"A murder happened"* is subject matter. The engine is a concrete uncertainty attached to a human consequence.
- 2. Make the antagonist a person whose choice you want to understand.** Curiosity about dangerous minds predicts consumption far more strongly than curiosity about bodily violation. **A situation is not a villain.**
- 3. Name a person and a threatened future, not a demographic.** One concrete human detail, earning its place.
- 4. The strongest movement is reclassification.** The accepted account stops holding. **A solved case becomes a failure of the record.**
- 5. Let the turn be a person, a lie or an identity.** A correction that arrives as arithmetic is true and inert.

★ ONE SEAM WORTH MINING

The top scorer and three others all turn on a group who share a lie: five friends with five keys, two sisters who gave word-for-word identical statements, four men who told the same story in the same wrong order, three children who drew the same visitor. **Something about a group holding one account is working on this reader.** Not a quota. A direction.

FOUR PROHIBITIONS

All four are empirical. Each one killed lines in round one. Note that three of them are about how a sentence reads rather than about what a story is, and those cost you nothing.

1. **No child and no elderly person as the victim or the central figure.** Ruled for the pilot specifically. Fine later; not here.
2. **No word a general reader would have to look up.** No trade, legal, medical or procedural vocabulary.
3. **No inversion, no withholding, no riddle.** See above. This is the one that killed the most.
4. **Nothing turning on paperwork,** in the sentence *or in the title*.

FORMAT

- **Title: six words or fewer,** evocative and specific, and **it must not smell of admin.**
- **Stinger: ONE sentence, thirty-five words or fewer,** understood on one read.
- **No proper nouns. No investigator, host or podcast in the sentence.**
- Number them 1 to 20. **No commentary, no rationale, no notes.**

MAKE YOUR OWN TWENTY DIVERSE

No two of your twenty should turn on the same central question. Vary who is dead, who is dangerous, who is left behind, and what kind of wrong the story is about.

WHAT YOU ARE NOT BEING ASKED FOR

No canon, no city detail, no research, no method, no access route, no structure. **Whether any of these can be built is somebody else's job, later.** Write the twenty most interesting one-line ideas you can, and make sure a stranger understands every one of them the first time.

PASTE TO HERE
